

Mung bean and caramelized fennel salad

I prefer a cast-iron skillet for this dish because it works so well with the **rich** caramelizing effects of the sugar. If you don't have one, substitute a sauté pan or other skillet.

Fennel varies greatly in size, so you may buy one large or two smaller bulbs to yield 2 cups [250g]. In either case, it doesn't matter much. You can always have more or less fennel in your salad. I prefer more. Serve with a side of Spicy Yogurt Sauce (page 111).

1 cup dried mung beans [200g]
2 cups coarsely chopped fennel bulb,
excluding stems and leaves [250g]
3 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil
2 tablespoons unrefined cane sugar
1 teaspoon crushed hot red pepper
2 garlic cloves, minced

2 tablespoons lemon juice
2 teaspoons soy sauce
¾ cup shredded radicchio [175ml]
4 scallions, thinly sliced
Salt and freshly ground pepper
2 tablespoons balsamic vinegar
1 cup bean sprouts [250ml]

1. **Soak** the mung beans in a large saucepan of cold water to cover for 6 to 8 hours or overnight. Drain and cover again with fresh water. Bring to a boil, reduce the heat to a simmer, and cook the beans until just tender, 45 to 60 minutes. If they get too soft, they tend to split open and make a less aesthetically pleasing salad. Drain and rinse the beans under cold water until the heat is completely dissipated. Drain well. Set aside in a large bowl.
2. In a large cast-iron skillet, **sauté** the fennel in 1½ tablespoons of the olive oil over medium heat, stirring occasionally, until lightly browned, about 10 minutes.

3. **Add** the sugar, hot pepper, and garlic. Raise the heat a spot so the sugar melts and bubbles, then return to medium heat and cook, stirring often, until the sugar caramelizes and coats the fennel, about 5 minutes.
4. Add 1 tablespoon of the lemon juice and 1 teaspoon of the soy sauce and cook, **stirring**, for another minute. Remove from the heat; add the fennel to the mung beans along with the radicchio and scallions. Toss with the remaining 1½ tablespoons olive oil, 1 tablespoon lemon juice, and 1 teaspoon soy sauce and the balsamic vinegar. Season with salt and pepper to taste.
5. Serve at room temperature. **Top** each plate with a small handful of bean sprouts.

SERVES 4 TO 6

